P. Chidambaram, have argued that more stimulus was needed—greater cash transfers, rations and financial decentralisation to the states[33]—along with a paradigmatic shift in economic management. While that may be so, by-elections held in fifty-nine constituencies across eleven Indian states in November 2020 suggest that the pandemic-induced recession had failed to dent the BJP's political momentum until that point. In these elections, across many parts of India—and the first after the lockdown—the BJP won almost two-thirds (forty-one) of the seats up for grabs. Significantly, these wins included major victories in the worst-hit Hindi heartland states (nineteen of twenty-eight in Madhya Pradesh, six of seven in UP), sustained political dominance in Gujarat (all eight), wins in South India (two of two in Karnataka; one of one in Telangana) and new advances in the Northeast (four of five in Manipur).[34]

Like the 2017 UP elections, which followed demonetisation, these nationwide by-polls in late 2020 were in part also seen as a political referendum on the Modi's government's handling of the pandemic. Far from shrinking, the BJP's political footprint had expanded significantly. Simultaneously, its NDA alliance managed to retain Bihar after three terms in power—despite facing serious incumbency, a spirited Opposition challenge and a severe migrant crisis. This is why Modi argued that the BJP's victories in these polls a few months *after* the first lockdown were even more significant than the Lok Sabha triumph of 2019. As he put it in a speech in November 2020, 'There is no one in the world who has not been effected by Corona … [However,] from the Janata [public] Curfew war until now, the way we fought this epidemic, these election results also show approval for that. In the time of Corona, from rations to employment for the poor, the level at which efforts were made in India, this is an approval of that.' The poll victories, he declared, were an endorsement of his direct-welfare policies. 'In our place, it is often said that bank accounts, gas connection, a house, self-employment opportunities, good roads, good railways, good railway stations, better airports, new modern bridges being built on rivers, internet connectivity—such issues don't matter in elections. You must have heard this. The public is again and again telling such people that these are the real issues … Those who don't understand